

BID CRAFT

VFX Script Breakdown · Bidding · Scheduling

Complete User Manual

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1 What BidCraft Is

BidCraft is a browser-based tool for VFX supervisors and producers that takes a raw screenplay all the way to a vendor-ready bid and a full crew schedule. It runs as a single **.html** file in any modern browser — no install, no login, no internet required after the first load. Everything stays in your browser's local storage; nothing is uploaded.

Because BidCraft is fully offline you can use it on confidential unreleased scripts. There is no server, no account, and no telemetry.

The six pages

Overview	Dashboard: total bid, budget split (artist / support / overhead / AI), cost-per-day, sequence and asset charts.
Breakdown	Paste or import a script, format it into screenplay layout, select VFX text, and tag it with categories, complexity, assets and notes. Colored bookmarks let you mark your reading position.
Review	A focused workspace showing only flagged shots and assets — ideal for a spotting session with the director.
Bidding	Full spreadsheet: every tagged shot and asset is a row, every department a column. Three tabs — Shots, Assets, AI Setups.
Compare	Snapshot the current bid and compare any two rounds to see exactly what changed.
Schedule	Set key dates, build an artist crew ramp from the bid, and plan support & supervision crew.

2 Getting Started

Opening BidCraft

Double-click **Project_BidCraft.html** and it opens in your default browser (Chrome, Edge, Safari, or Firefox). That is the entire setup — everything works immediately, including offline.

Installing as an app (optional)

For BidCraft in its own window with a dock or taskbar icon, serve the PWA folder locally and install from the address bar:

- **Serve:** In the unzipped PWA folder run `python3 -m http.server 8080`
- **Open:** Visit `http://localhost:8080` in Chrome or Edge
- **Install:** Click the install icon in the address bar. BidCraft opens standalone and works fully offline thereafter.

Blocked by IT? Launch a standalone window with Chrome's app mode: a shortcut whose target ends in `--app="file:///path/to/index.html"`. No server needed.

Loading the example project

A complete 186-shot sci-fi feature — **INVASION — Example Project** — ships alongside BidCraft. Load it via **File** → **Load project**. It includes 19 departments, 23 assets, 4 AI Setups applied to 158 shots, a full artist ramp, support crew, two bid snapshots, and bid templates. Use it to explore every feature before starting your own show.

Loading a project file always creates a new project slot — your existing work is never overwritten.

3 The Interface

The top bar

BIDCRAFT logo	Links to Mathieu Vierendeel's LinkedIn.
Project switcher	Drop-down listing all open projects. + creates a new one; the pencil renames it; the bin deletes it.
Page tabs	Overview · Breakdown · Review · Bidding · Compare · Schedule.
File menu	All import/export and project save/load functions.
Sun button	Toggle light / dark mode.
Calendar cog	Project settings (key dates, closures, milestones).
Gear cog	Studio settings (rates, currency, time unit, feature flags).

Autosave

BidCraft saves to your browser continuously as you work. Every edit is written to localStorage. To move data between machines or keep a durable backup, use **File** → **Save project** — this creates a portable .json file you can reload anywhere.

Autosave is browser-specific. Clearing browser data removes it. Hard-refresh (Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+R) after downloading a new version to clear the offline cache.

4 The Overview Page

The dashboard gives a live summary of the entire project at a glance. It updates as you bid.

Stats row

Total shots	Count of tagged shots with a non-zero shot number.
Total bid days	Shots + assets combined, including the shot count multiplier.
Cost per day	Weighted average day-rate across all departments.
Total cost	Department days × rates + producer offsets + AI offsets.

Budget split bar

Shows Artist & assets · Support crew · Overhead · AI as proportional segments. When AI produces a net saving the bar stays at 100% and the saving is shown in the legend as a deduction.

	Artist & assets
	Support crew
	Overhead
	AI setups

Sequence & asset charts

Horizontal bar charts ranked by bid days (or shot count when budgeting is off). A quick way to see where the budget is concentrated.

5 The Breakdown Page

Where a script becomes a tagged breakdown. The left pane holds the script; the right pane holds the tagging tools.

Getting your script in

- **Paste** — copy text from a PDF, Word, or Final Draft export straight into the script pane.
- **Import script PDF** — from the File menu, a drag-and-drop dialog reads a script PDF locally and rebuilds its line structure.
- **Import shots from Excel / CSV** — from the File menu, load a spreadsheet of shots; a preview lets you map columns.

Format Screenplay

The **Format Screenplay** button rebuilds pasted text into clean screenplay layout: detects scene headings (INT./EXT.), strips page numbers, bolds ALL-CAPS cues, and centres character names.

Colored bookmarks

The **Bookmarks** button sits between Format Screenplay and the red Clear button. Use it to drop a colored marker at your current position:

- **Add** — pick one of five colors from the picker. A marker is placed at the cursor, or at the top of the visible area if no cursor is in the script.
- **Jump** — click any bookmark in the list to scroll back to it with a brief flash animation.
- **Timestamp** — each bookmark shows the date and time it was created, plus a short label pulled from the surrounding script text.
- **Delete** — click the × on any bookmark to remove it. Clearing the script clears all bookmarks.

Bookmarks are saved with the project and survive reload — stored as invisible anchor spans embedded in the script HTML.

Selecting & tagging text

1. **Select** the text describing an effect — the whole selection stays highlighted yellow.
2. **Set scene, shot & count** — scene auto-fills from the heading above. Set 'No shots' if the selection represents several shots.
3. **Pick tags, complexity, assets & notes** — choose VFX tags, set complexity, add assets, fill assumptions / methodology.
4. Press **Tag VFX** (or **■/Ctrl + Enter**) — the yellow selection turns gold and a card appears in Tagged Shots.

Highlights are linked. Click a gold highlight to jump to its card; click a card to jump back to the script. Deleting a shot removes its highlight automatically.

Clear script

The **Clear** button (red, with trash icon) deletes all script text. A confirmation dialog warns you — tagged shots remain in the bid but lose their script highlight links. The action is undoable (■/Ctrl+Z).

6 Tags, Complexities & Assets

VFX tags & groups

Tags are organised into coloured groups (2D Comp & DMP, Crowds, 3D Full CGI, 3D Enviro, 3D Object, 3D Character, 3D FX, Previs, Assets, and more). In the Tags & Complexities tab you can rename tags, reassign groups, add your own, or delete unused ones.

Complexities & levels

VERY EASY · 1	Simple paint-outs, single-element comps
EASY · 2	Screen replacements, basic cleanup
MEDIUM · 3	Set extensions, moderate comps
HARD · 4	Full CG objects, integrated FX
VERY HARD · 5	CG characters, complex simulations
COMPLEX · 6	Hero full-CG shots, multi-discipline

Assets

Assets are reusable items — a creature, vehicle, or environment — that appear across many shots. Type an asset name and press Enter to add it; it joins a dropdown you toggle per shot. Start typing an existing name and press Tab to autocomplete.

- **Rename** — updates on every shot at once.
- **Delete** — removes from all shots with a warning showing how many.
- Assets get their own rows in the Bidding sheet's Assets tab, so you can bid asset builds separately from shot work.

Set up once, reuse everywhere. Your tags, complexities, departments and rates can be saved as a Settings file (Studio settings → Export settings) and imported into every new show.

7 The Bidding Page

A full spreadsheet where every tagged shot and asset is a row and every department a column. Three tabs — Shots, Assets, AI Setups.

Columns

Shot / Asset	The frozen identifier. Editable — type SCENE_SHOT to rename.
Description	The selected script text (wraps).
Cx	Complexity level (shots only).
#	Number of shots / assets — multiplies days & cost.
Departments	One editable day-count cell per department.
Days / Weeks	Sum of department days $\times$ #.
Cost	Department days $\times$ rates $\times$ # (before offset).
AI Setup / AI \$	AI setup attached to this row and its cost (when expanded).
Producer Offset	Manual $\pm$ \$ adjustment.
Total Cost	Cost + producer offset + AI offset.

Hiding & reordering department columns

Hover over any department header to reveal a small action bar:

- **← → arrows** — move the column left or right. Same order appears in the Schedule. Undo works.
- **Eye icon** — hide the column. All bid data is preserved; the column collapses to a narrow stripe. Click any stripe to restore.
- **× icon** — delete the column and all its bid data.

A **Cols** button appears in the bid toolbar whenever any columns are hidden. Click it to restore all at once.

Count of zero = parked

Set a row's # to 0 to exclude it from days, costs, and the schedule. The row greys out with a 'no vfx' label. Useful for holding a shot in the bid without it counting.

Shift-click range selection

Click one checkbox, hold Shift, then click another — every row between takes the same state (select or deselect). Works in both directions.

Templates & manual rows

Bid one row, tick it, **Save as template**, then tick others and **Apply to selected**. A template fully overwrites a row's department days — departments not in the template are cleared. **Add shot / Add asset** creates a row that wasn't tagged from the script.

Bulk actions

Tick rows, then open the Bulk menu to act on them all:

- Select all / clear · set complexity · add a tag · set # shots · park (# = 0)
- Flag or unflag for review · clear department days
- **Apply AI Setup...** — attach or detach an AI Setup across all ticked rows (scope-aware).
- Duplicate rows · delete rows — each action is a single undoable step.

8 AI Setups

AI Setups is a third bidding tab alongside Shots and Assets. Each setup is a reusable workflow line representing a repeatable AI tool or pipeline — something you build once and apply to many shots or assets.

The model

Build cost	Software license + GPU/cloud spend + build days × build rate. Counted ONCE for the project. Appears as its own line in the Schedule's AI SETUPS row.
Per-use offset	A ± figure applied to each shot or asset the setup is attached to, multiplied by the shot count. Can be negative (a net saving).
Per-entry override	Open any shot or asset row and enter a custom offset for that entry only. Overridden entries show in gold.
Scope	Shot / Asset / Both — controls which row types the setup can attach to.

Creating a setup

On the AI Setups tab, click **Add AI Setup**. Fill in name, software, category, note, software cost, GPU cost, build days, build department, build rate, per-use offset, and scope.

Applying setups

Use the AI Setup dropdown in the AI column of any shot or asset row (click the **AI** button in the toolbar to expand the AI columns). To apply to many rows at once, tick them and use **Bulk** → **Apply AI Setup...**

Build cost is counted ONCE at the project level — not per shot. Per-use offset flows into each shot/asset Total Cost. The Overview dashboard shows AI as its own slice in the budget split.

How costs appear in the dashboard

Artist & assets	Department bid days × rate + producer offsets. AI offsets are kept separate.
AI setups	Per-use offsets × count (all shots/assets) + build cost once. Shown in blue.
Total project	Artist + Support + Overhead + AI.

When AI produces a net saving (negative total), the budget bar stays at 100% and the saving is annotated in the legend below the bar.

Excel export

The Excel export includes a dedicated **AI Setups** sheet with per-setup build costs, offsets, and usage counts. The Bid sheet includes an AI \$ column and a project total row with AI build cost.

Schedule integration

The **AI SETUPS** row at the top of the artist crew ramp (blue, all-caps) carries the combined build days of all applied setups. It participates in all three auto-fill modes — flat, only-fill-empty, and phased — with its own window, curve, and head cap in the phased modal (default: 0–30%, Ramp curve).

9 The Review Page

A focused workspace for the shots and assets that need discussion — ideal for a spotting session with the director.

Flagging

Every shot card, bidding row, and asset has a flag icon. Click it red and that item appears on the Review page; everything else stays out of the way.

The Review cards

- **Left** — the shot's full context: code, badges, tags, assets, description, assumptions and methodology, with an arrow to jump to it in the script.
- **Right** — two free-text notepads: Producer — questions & answers, and VFX Supervisor — questions & answers.

Notes save live and travel with the project. Unflag an item to clear it from the list.

10 The Compare Page

Bids change as the cut changes. Snapshots freeze a dated copy of the numbers so you can see exactly what moved between rounds.

Snapshots

Press **Snapshot this bid** to freeze every shot and asset's days and cost, plus totals, as a named dated copy saved with the project. Each can be renamed or deleted.

Comparing two rounds

Two drop-downs let you compare any snapshot against another — or against the live current bid:

- **Summary** — delta days, delta cost, delta shot count (red = increase, green = decrease).
- **Scenes** — aggregated day & cost change per scene.
- **Shots** — every changed shot grouped under its scene, with new / removed badges.
- **Assets** — every changed asset build.

Snapshot at the end of each bidding round. When the next cut arrives, the Compare page tells you precisely where the budget moved.

11 The Schedule Page

Key dates

Start — green	The awarded / kick-off date.
Turnovers TO01–TO10 — blue	Numbered client turnover dates.
Custom milestones — gold	Your own named dates (start edit, trailer delivery, lock...). Up to 20.
Delivery — red	The final deadline. The schedule spans from Start to Delivery.

Set all dates in **Project settings** (calendar cog, top-right). Studio closures (holidays, hiatus) are also set here — closed weeks are hatched in the ramp grid and skipped by auto-fill.

Artist crew ramp

A grid of department rows × week columns. Type heads per week (decimals fine). Cells shade blue by crew size. The right-hand **Sched / Budget** column tracks scheduled person-weeks against each department's bid-day budget.

Reordering departments

Hover any department row label to reveal ▲ / ▼ arrows. Click to move the department up or down. The same order appears in the Bidding page. Undo works.

AI SETUPS row

The blue **AI SETUPS** row at the top of the ramp carries the combined build days of all applied setups. It is filled by auto-fill alongside regular departments.

Auto-fill from bid

The **Auto-fill from bid** button generates a starting crew ramp from the bid days. Three modes:

- **Flat average** — spreads each department's budget evenly across all working weeks.
- **Only fill empty rows** — same as flat but skips any line that already has crew scheduled.
- **Phased ramp** — opens a configuration modal where you set a phase window (start %, end % of the schedule) and a curve shape for each department and the AI line.

Phase curves

Ramp	Front-loaded — builds fast, peaks early.
Bell	Symmetrical peak in the middle of the window.
Plateau	Flat in the middle, tapers at each end.
Ramp-up	Builds through the window, peaks at the end.

A **head cap** can be set per department to prevent the curve from scheduling more than a given number of heads in any one week. If the cap prevents placing the full budget, a warning lists the overflow.

Auto-fill never overwrites departments that already have crew in the visible schedule weeks. Departments with crew in now-hidden weeks (from a shortened schedule) are correctly recognised as empty and will be re-filled.

Support crew

Press **Add support role** and pick from your studio rate presets. Two role types:

- **Daily (\$/day)** — heads per week × days per week × rate.
- **% of crew** — a percentage of (artist + support heads) × rate × dpw, summed per week.

Schedule summary bar

A bar at the bottom shows: artist days vs support days, and — when budgeting is on — artist cost, support cost, overhead cost, AI cost, and the combined project total.

12 Studio & Project Settings

Project settings (calendar cog)

Key dates: Start, Final delivery, Turnovers TO01–TO10, Custom milestones, and Non-working periods (closures). The schedule rebuilds whenever a date changes.

Studio settings (gear cog)

Department day rate	Set one rate and apply to all departments at once.
Currency	USD, EUR, GBP, CAD, AUD, JPY, CNY. Labels cost totals; does not convert numbers.
Time unit	Days or Weeks. Bids are stored in days; Weeks just divides the displayed figures.
Support & overhead rates	Day-rate presets for VFX Supervisor, Producer, Coordinator, General Overhead. Offered when adding support crew on Schedule.
Features	Toggle whole modules on/off. See Section 15.

Changing currency relabels cost totals; it does not apply exchange rates to numbers already entered.

13 The File Menu & Exports

Import

Import script PDF	Read a screenplay PDF locally into the script pane.
Import shots from Excel/CSV	Load a spreadsheet of shots. A preview dialog maps columns; detects department day columns and offers to create new departments. Rows are added, not merged.

Export

Export to Excel	A real .xlsx workbook: Breakdown, Summary, Bid (with AI \$ columns and AI build cost line), Schedule, and — when AI Setups are active — a dedicated AI Setups sheet.
Export to CSV	A flat breakdown file. Scene and shot numbers keep their leading zeros.
Export for ShotGrid	Two CSVs shaped for ShotGrid's importer: a Shots file and an Assets file.
Export AI Setups	A standalone JSON of just the AI Setups, importable into any project.

Project & settings

Save project	A complete backup of one show (script, shots, assets, bids, schedule, snapshots, AI Setups). Use it to move between machines or share with a colleague.
Load project	Loads a .json file as a new project slot — your existing projects are never overwritten.
Export settings	The reusable studio setup only (tags, departments, rates, templates, overhead presets). No project content.
Import settings	Load a settings file into the current project. Build your studio standard once; import into every new show.

14 Projects & Autosave

BidCraft stores all your projects in a single `localStorage` object containing a list of project slots. Every edit writes the live state into the active project's data slot and saves the whole store. Switching projects saves first, then loads. Creating a new project saves first, then adds a blank slot.

Data-loss risks

- **Browser-specific** — projects only exist in the browser + machine where you did the work. Clearing browser data removes everything. Use File → Save project for a portable backup.
- **Private windows** — don't share `localStorage` with normal windows. Don't use BidCraft in private mode unless you save the project file at the end.

A full 186-shot project with AI Setups, a complete schedule, and two snapshots takes about 154 KB. The 5 MB `localStorage` limit fits roughly 32 projects that size — not a real concern in practice.

15 Appearance & Feature Flags

Light / dark mode

The sun button (top-right) flips the entire app between dark and light. Tagged highlights stay readable in both.

Feature flags (Studio settings → Features)

Budgeting	Off → removes Bidding and Compare tabs. BidCraft becomes a pure breakdown + review tool.
Scheduling	Off → removes the Schedule tab.
Hide all prices	Keeps bidding and scheduling fully usable but blanks every monetary figure — useful when sharing a screen where costs shouldn't be visible.

16 Shortcuts & Tips

Keyboard shortcuts

■/Ctrl + Enter	Tag the current script selection
■/Ctrl + Z	Undo the last destructive action (outside text fields)
Enter / ↓	Move down a cell in the bid grid
← ↑ ↓ →	Move between bid cells
Tab / arrows	Confirm a ramp cell and move to the next week (Schedule)
Tab	Autocomplete an asset name while typing
Esc	Close a popup or the File menu
?	Open the shortcuts reference

Tips for speed

- Build a settings file with your standard tags, departments, rates and overhead presets and import it into every show.
- Use bid templates for repetitive shot types instead of typing days row by row.
- Use # (count) to represent a run of identical shots as one entry; set it to 0 to park a shot.
- Use Shift-click to select a range of rows before applying a bulk action.
- Use the sequence groups and filters to bid one sequence, department or asset type at a time.
- Snapshot each bidding round so Compare can show you exactly what changed.
- Save project regularly — autosave is convenient, but a saved file is your real backup.

Troubleshooting

A change doesn't appear	Hard-refresh (Ctrl/Cmd+Shift+R) — the offline cache can be sticky after updates.
Leading zeros lost in Excel	The CSV writes scene/shot as text formulas — open the file fresh rather than re-importing a stripped copy.
PDF import asks for internet	The PDF engine loads once online, then is cached. Offline, paste the text instead.

Lost data after clearing browser

Restore from your most recent saved project file.

Auto-fill does nothing

Check the toast message — it will say either 'no bid days' (go to Bidding first) or 'already staffed in visible weeks' (clear the schedule or use a longer delivery date).